

The Presence Hypothesis

On the nature of presence — a layered statement

Dustin Ogle · Satyalogos Inc. · ORCID 0009-0000-0372-6227

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*A layered statement of the presence proposal, disciplined so that what is claimed, why it is better, and what could count as evidence are kept apart. It is a hypothesis, not a finished theory: the claim is stated first, its advantages are offered only as support after it stands, and the evidence it invites concerns the structures presence localizes through, never presence itself. Registers are marked — [E] a first-hand datum, [P] a posit offered and not established, [O] an open question, [T] a formal or demonstrated result, [A] an analogy — and one discipline governs the whole, **Relational Relativity**: where a claim differs between the standpoint of a bounded locus and the standpoint of the undifferentiated whole, both are meant, and neither cancels the other. The fuller exploration, with its lineage and its prose, is the companion essay Relational Relativity — presence, will, and the deeper relativity; this is its spine.*

Thesis

Presence is not an emergent property added to structure, and not a micro-property combined upward from parts. It is the inside face of the fundamental self-limitation of the Unified; structure is the outside face of that same move. Physics measures the outside face, and only ever the outside face — relation, quantity, frequency, invariance. Experience is the localization of presence within bounded relational loci. Presence itself remains unmeasurable, by definition; but the structures through which it localizes can be modeled, compared, and tested.

Everything below is that thesis, taken one layer at a time.

Defining the term: “presence” as the isolated residue

The word this hypothesis turns on is not the everyday one, and it is not “consciousness.” It is a term of art, fixed by a decomposition first set out in *Relation Before Relata*, and the argument is unreadable without it — so it is drawn before anything is claimed.

The method is to take the overloaded words of the debate — *consciousness*, *experience*, *observer* — and separate the several jobs each has been made to carry, so that the disputes bred by their fusion dissolve while the one genuinely hard thing is not dissolved but *isolated*. *Consciousness* fuses four: the capacity to access and act on information, the capacity to report, the modelling of oneself, and — distinct from all three — the bare fact that there is something it is like to be the system at all. The first three are structural: hard as engineering is hard, but not mysterious in kind, and reachable in principle by a functional account. The fourth reduces to none of them. *Experience* fuses two: the localized participation of an organization in the structure it belongs to — what it is coupled to, what it resolves, what it is closed off from — which is structural; and whether that participation is accompanied by anything it is like to undergo, which is not a further structure but the fourth thing again, under another name. *Observer*, drained of the knower it usually smuggles in, is only a *reference decomposition* — a way of factoring a whole into a part and a remainder — and neither sees nor chooses nor knows. Across all three, the same residue survives every separation.

That residue is **presence** — *intrinsic presence*, given the neutral name so the structural senses cannot leak back in. It is defined negatively, and the negativity is the nature of the thing, not an evasion: intrinsic presence is whatever would distinguish a relational configuration that has an inside from one exhaustively described from without. To fix it is to draw a line around what no structural description captures — determination is negation — so it can be indicated by that line and never exhibited directly. This is not “consciousness,” most of which is structural and, in this account, tractable. Presence is only the remainder — the bare inside — and the whole hypothesis concerns that remainder and nothing else.

Two notes keep the definition honest. It has precedent — Block’s access-versus-phenomenal, Chalmers’s easy-versus-hard each split a word that had been doing several jobs — and it goes past them in three ways: the decomposition is driven by a positive ontology rather than assembled term by term; it is applied across the whole vocabulary (experience, observer, self, matter, mind, separation), not to “consciousness” alone; and it terminates not in a reduction but in a single residue it can isolate and cannot remove. And the words came fused for a reason that is not carelessness but a reasonable over-generalization from the only inside any of us knows from within — the human case, where access, report, self-model, and presence always travel together. With one sample in which the parts never come apart, it was natural to bind them into one word; the decomposition is the recognition that, in principle, they can.

Layer 1 — The datum [E]

With the term fixed, the datum is the one thing not inferred. That residue — the bare inside the decomposition isolated — is given first-hand, prior to any theory and more certain than any; it is the single datum no argument reaches behind, since to doubt it is already to have it. Its second property the definition has already drawn, and

this layer only insists on it: presence is not, in itself, a structural quantity, because it was fixed as precisely the remainder no structural description captures. No measure of organization, integration, or information is the feltness; each is a quantity of structure, and the feltness is what remains when every such quantity is fixed. So the datum arrives with its boundary already drawn — presence is the most certain thing there is, and it is not a piece of structure — and that pair rules out the two easy exits at the door. It refutes the eliminativist, who must deny the given; and it forbids the identity theorist's shortcut, who must equate the given with a structure it is defined to exceed.

Layer 2 — The ontological hypothesis [P]

The hypothesis: presence and structure are not two things needing a bridge, and not one thing with the other explained away. They are the **two faces of a single move** — what it is, felt from within; how it is organized, read from without. Presence is the inside; structure is the outside; and there is exactly one move of which they are the faces.

This is the load-bearing claim, and its strength is what it refuses. It refuses to make *relation* the sole foundation — the structuralist's "relations without relata," forever owing an answer to *relations between what?* and never saying why any of it is lit from within. And it refuses to make *qualia* the sole foundation — the intrinsic base of Russellian monism and panpsychism, forever owing the combination problem, how micro-feels sum to one mind. Neither is the floor; both are faces of the one move, and so neither is owed the other's debt. There are no relata to supply, because the relata are later knots in the same move; and there is no combination to perform, because presence is one inside localized downward, never many insides summed upward. That single refusal — *neither face is the foundation; both are faces* — is the hypothesis's claim to be new work rather than a restatement of either camp.

Layer 3 — The generative hypothesis [P]

What is the move a face of? The hypothesis: it is the fundamental self-limitation of the Unified — the undifferentiated whole, in which nothing is yet separate, tending into its first difference. Call the move a **tending**: not a thing acting, not an agent choosing, not a desire in any human sense, but the irreducible self-moving of unity into limitation. It needs nothing outside itself to move it, because there is nothing outside; and it is not compelled by a law, because a law is already a plural structure and there is none yet. It is prior to the fork it is usually forced into — neither necessity, which needs a law to compel, nor contingency, which needs a menu to choose among — for both of those presuppose the plurality the tending is the first of. In the barest terms it is a self-moving that is neither compelled nor arbitrary.

There is a sharper version of the same fork, and it too lapses. Ask whether the Unified *must* differentiate or *wills* to — whether the first move is compelled or elected —

and the question already assumes a law standing over unity or a chooser standing behind it, when there is neither; self-relation is not enforced and not elected but is *what unity is*, the coincidence of freedom and necessity Spinoza found in a substance whose acting and whose being are one. This is the resolution reached in *Relation Before Relata*: the must-or-wills fork is not answered but dissolved, and exactly one question outlives its dissolving. Not *whether* unity differentiates — that is settled by its being self-relation — but whether that self-relating has an inside. The surviving question is the presence question, which is this hypothesis's whole subject.

Two words in this layer need discipline, because both are standpoint-relative and both invite the wrong reading.

The first is *will*. The tradition's name for a subjectless, objectless self-moving — Schopenhauer's Will beneath representation, the *conatus*, the first throb the Shaivites called *spanda* — is will, and once it is stripped of a willer, of a thing willed, and of deliberation, it names this tending exactly. The word is kept, but demoted. The theory rides on **tending**, the neutral structural term; *will* is only its purified traditional name, introduced after the willer and the willed are already gone, so that no agency, choice, or desire is smuggled into the ground. A reader who hears theology or psychology in it is hearing what the demotion is designed to remove.

The second is *first*. From a locus, the tending is the **first** move — first in the sequence that locus perceives as its time. From the whole there is no time for it to be earlier in, so it is not earlier than anything; it is simply the **fundamental** tending, present, the standing root of every moment rather than a past event. "First" is therefore exact provided it is heard *sub specie durationis* — first in a locus's perceived sequence — and "fundamental" is its name *sub specie aeternitatis*. The tending is first from within and fundamental from the whole, one move under two standpoints, which is the next layer's business.

Whether that fundamental tending is blind or yearning — a bare self-moving, or a tending that in some sense *wants* its own differentiation — is left open [O]. The hypothesis needs only that it tends; the temperature of the ground is a further and separable question.

Layer 4 — The interpretive principle: Relational Relativity

One principle governs how every claim above is to be read, and without it they read as contradictions. **Relational Relativity**: a description is relative to the standpoint it is made from; the reality it describes is invariant across standpoints; and where the standpoints diverge, more than one description is true at once. Two standpoints matter. A *locus* is a finite, bounded vantage inside the unfolding — your seat as you read this — from which the world is many, separate, and in time, each of those fully real. *Unity* is the undifferentiated whole, from which there are no separate things and no before or after, only the one present. The same reality read from the two seats yields descriptions that look like flat contradictions — many and one, timed and

timeless, first and fundamental, bounded and whole — and the rule is not to pick a winner but to name the seat and let both stand. This is not a mystical license. It is the same structure as physical relativity, where a quantity is frame-relative while the reality is invariant across frames, generalized from inertial frames to standpoints as such — and it is what keeps the hypothesis from collapsing into a paradox that was never in it.

Layer 5 — The scientific bridge [T / A]

The hypothesis draws a sharp line for science and honors it. Physics measures the *outside* face and only the outside face — relation, quantity, frequency, invariance, everything that survives a change of frame. It never measures presence, because presence is the inside, the residue structure is defined to exclude. This is not a wall against inquiry; it is a correct account of what the instrument is for. And on the outside face there is already exact, checked work: that a construction wholly of relation, with no substance in it, can be made covariant, completely positive, and exact, and can do real work (the exact $Sp(3)$ relational channel, machine-verified, trace-preserving and — under a stated convention premise — action-determined); that covariance and its invariants are exactly reducible and independently verifiable (the $USp(4)$ and $USp(6) = Sp(3)$ compression results, exact rational certificates, verifiers returning ALL PASS); that definiteness is a relation formed and not a property revealed (the double-slit reading). These are demonstrated results about the outside face [T]. With respect to the ontology they are offered as [A] only — a suggestive shape, never evidence that reality is so built. The bridge carries traffic one way: the hypothesis tells physics where its domain ends; physics never tells the hypothesis that its ontology is true.

Layer 6 — Where evidence could accumulate [O]

Presence cannot be detected, so the program never looks for it. It looks instead at the *structures through which presence would localize* — boundary, definiteness, time, covariance, self-relation — and makes one wager about them: **the hypothesis is not tested by detecting presence, but by asking whether the structural places where presence would localize are exactly the places where our present theories already expose an unresolved dependence on relation.** Where a mature theory has had to leave relation, boundary, definiteness, or time *primitive* — assumed rather than derived — the hypothesis predicts the cleaner structure comes from treating that primitive as the localizing move, not the floor.

Five fronts follow, ordered from the most concrete to the most speculative. Each names what current theory leaves primitive, what the hypothesis predicts structurally, and what kind of result would count as support — and none of them is a measurement of the inside.

1 • Measurement and definiteness. *Left primitive:* quantum theory gives the statistics of outcomes exactly, but must insert by hand *when* a possibility becomes a fact

— the measurement problem, managed by a classical/quantum cut no equation locates. *Predicted*: definiteness is never absolute; it is constituted in a fixing relation, and appears only where which-path information is actually created and cannot be recovered. *What would count*: that the coming and going of definite outcomes track entanglement and its breaking — which-path marking, decoherence, quantum erasure — with no residue that needs an observer’s mind. This is the front where the relevant experiments already exist and where the account has already stated its reading (the double-slit paper); and it says the exact opposite of “consciousness collapses the wavefunction” — the fixing is structural, not mental.

2 • Boundary and localization. *Left primitive*: the sciences of living and cognitive systems assume a system already marked off from its world — the boundary is drawn before the theory begins. *Predicted*: a locus exists only where a boundary can *carry a model of its own coupling* instead of dissolving it; there is a threshold between a boundary that preserves the coherence a model needs and one that merely breaks correlation. *What would count*: a sharp structural characterization of that threshold — in the language of Markov blankets and coherence-preserving versus entanglement-breaking coupling — placing model-sustaining organizations on one side and merely reactive ones on the other. This is the cleanest bridge; the free-energy / Markov-blanket work is where it starts, and the prediction is that localization becomes possible *at all* precisely there.

3 • Time and clocking. *Left primitive*: fundamental physics writes its laws against a time it does not derive, and in quantum gravity the “problem of time” is exactly that the background parameter has nowhere left to stand. *Predicted*: metric time is not fundamental; it appears where a locus can clock a rhythm — a bounded system carrying internal correlations that keep a rate — and nowhere else. The whole has sequence but no measure. *What would count*: relational and quantum-clock formulations in which metric time *emerges* from correlations internal to bounded subsystems rather than being assumed as a backdrop — duration defined exactly where a locus can clock it, undefined where none can. A live instance of this frontier has just been realized: a cold-atom “quantum Galileo” interferometer (Dobkowski et al., *Sci. Adv.* **12**, eaec8045, 2026) that measures the quantum phase of a freely falling wave packet against a stationary reference held in the laboratory frame, and confirms the phase the equivalence principle predicts in the quantum domain — a case where phase, gravity, frame, and clocking meet in one experimentally accessible relational structure, the freely falling and laboratory descriptions cohering through a single gauge phase [A].

4 • Covariance and Planck-scale structure. *Left primitive*: our deepest theories still begin with points in space and moments in time, then strain to keep that starting stuff coherent at the Planck scale. *Predicted*: if spacetime is late structure — a stabilized relation, not the floor — the most fundamental physics should not begin with points and moments at all, but with relational invariants, distinguishability, covariance, and the limits of measurement. *What would count*: that a construction made

wholly of relation, with no substance in it, can be covariant, completely positive, and exact, and can be machine-verified to be so — which the relational-channel and compression results demonstrate on the outside face [T]. To the ontology these stay [A], a suggestive shape and never a proof; what they establish is that the relational starting point is *constructible and consistent* — the entry price for the deeper claim. This is the highest-risk front, and it promises nothing about “predicting quantum gravity.” The same quantum-Galileo experiment’s stated outlook — toward clock wave packets, nanodiamond interferometers, and tests bearing on the quantization of gravity and gravitationally induced collapse — points straight into this front: it marks where a “spacetime as late relational structure” wager should watch for whether the deepest layer reads more cleanly in relational invariants than in points and moments [A].

5 • Mind and the built locus. *Left primitive:* theories of mind assume a subject and hunt for its neural or computational correlates, leaving the subject’s boundary and the continuity of its experience as givens. *Predicted:* felt continuity, arising, and the sense of a self track a specific *structure* — a cyclic, returning organization with an access boundary between what it represents and what it does not — and should survive a change of the underlying substrate, because presence localizes through the structure, not the material. *What would count:* that such an organization, built and run, reproduces the structural signatures of a locus — continuity, return, an access edge — independently of substrate. The Ellipse Mind Model is one such structure, offered as an existence proof of the *shape* [A], never as evidence that anything is felt inside it.

The order is deliberate: the first two fronts touch demonstrated or near-demonstrated work, the middle two are live frontiers where the hypothesis makes a directional bet, and the last is an existence proof of structure. None of the five measures presence. Each asks the one question a program built on an unmeasurable inside is entitled to ask — whether the places our theories still leave primitive are the very places the hypothesis says the localizing move must be.

What the measurement work teaches

Core claim. The measurement work gives a concrete case in which relational structure reaches lawful transformation and exact evaluative return, but not actual selection. This does not prove presence; it locates the kind of gap the Presence Hypothesis is meant to name.

The relational measurement analysis (companion note, *Relational Measurement*) is the first Layer 6 front carried far enough to report a lesson, and the lesson is disciplinary, not evidential: it sharpens what presence is *not*, and where — if anywhere — it could bear on measurement, while offering no evidence that it does. In one sentence: the measurement work does not identify presence with collapse; it shows why presence should not be looked for as another operator inside the measurement formalism. If presence is relevant here, it is relevant at the boundary between structurally

available outcomes and actuality, not as a hidden mechanism among the structural terms.

The $\text{Sp}(3)$ scoring result makes this sharp, by an instructive route. One object in the construction yields, at once, a channel action ($N = L^T$), an evaluative score, and a passage that is coherent or classicalized. The scoring row first *looked* like a measurement effect — a POVM element, just the kind of object one might have hoped presence hides behind. It failed that test exactly (its operator is provably not self-adjoint), then resolved positively into a sector-return figure of merit of the channel, $\text{Tr}[P_s N(P_s)]/d_s$ — a legitimate positive evaluation of the map, computed entirely from structure [T]. So the formalism reached *further* than expected: it represents structural action, sector-return evaluation, and the retention or loss of coherence, each to the last exact rational — and still, in that worked case, none of that inventory contains the fact that *this* outcome, rather than another, is the one realized.

That is the whole use of the result here, and it cuts against a tempting but wrong reading of the hypothesis. **Presence does not cause collapse; presence is not a scoring function; presence is not a POVM effect.** The measurement work adds presence to physics as none of these; it exhibits a case where the structural description is unusually complete — channel, scoring, return-fidelity, coherent-versus-classical passage — and *still* does not, by itself, fix which structurally available outcome becomes actual. Presence, if it belongs near measurement at all, belongs at exactly that boundary: where the inventory is complete as structure yet does not contain actuality-as-selected.

A final lesson comes from *how* the structure was secured, and it bears directly on the discipline presence demands. The sector-return structure was invisible — worse, actively distorted — when the diagonal sub-channels were read in the naive Euclidean frame: that reading returned a non-Hermitian, non-positive object with a spurious rank and spectrum. Only in the construction’s own metric (G_W -orthonormal) frame did the real structure appear — Hermitian, positive, low rank, exactly balanced. This is a concrete mathematical instance of a principle the ontology leans on elsewhere: *what appears in one representational frame can be a property of the frame, not of the thing*. The corrective is to change frames before crediting a structure to the object. That is exactly the anti-reification discipline presence requires. If a quantity as structural as a Choi spectrum can be a frame-artifact, the temptation to reify presence into whatever operator, score, or invariant a given formalism happens to expose is the same error one level deeper — and the same corrective applies: presence is not to be identified with any structure that a particular frame makes salient.

Two disciplines keep the lesson honest. It is negative boundary evidence, never positive proof: nothing here shows *where* outcome selection occurs, *why* it occurs, or that presence is involved at all; only that a rich, exact structural inventory can be assembled up to the near side of selection and stop there [O]. And the completeness is reported for the worked construction, not proved in general — that exact structure

reaches channel, scoring, and fidelity but not selection is established for this $Sp(3)$ specimen, its general form open [O]. What the result licenses is therefore modest, and for that reason usable: outcome selection is named as one candidate site where the presence-boundary that front 1 already watches may become physically sharp, and presence is disqualified — cleanly — from being any of the structural objects on the near side of it.

Why this is better than the alternatives — support, not claim

Offered only now, after the claim stands, and never turned back to establish it. Against **materialism and idealism**, the hypothesis declines the premise both share — that reality is at bottom a stuff — while keeping matter fully real as a stable relation. Against **dualism**, it posits no second substance and inherits no interaction problem, because inside and outside are one move. Against **structuralism**, it answers *relations between what?* — nothing owed; the relata are downstream knots. Against **panpsychism**, it has no combination problem, because presence is localized top-down rather than summed bottom-up. Against **illusionism**, it keeps the one datum instead of spending it to save a theory. Every advantage has the same shape: the hypothesis pays a debt the alternative could not, because it set the foundation one step deeper — at the move whose two faces the others each mistook, one or the other, for the floor.

What the hypothesis claims, and what it does not

It claims that presence is real and given [E]; that presence and structure are two faces of one move [P]; that the move is the fundamental tending of the Unified [P]; and that experience is presence localized within bounded loci [P]. It does **not** claim to have *explained* presence. The hard problem is dissolved in one precise sense only — as a *demand for a structural bridge* from organization to an inside, a demand that lapses because there is no bridge to build when inside and outside are already one move. The residue the hard problem named is not dissolved: presence remains, real and unmeasurable by design, exactly as Layer 1 gave it. The hypothesis explains the *misframing* of the problem, not the feltness — it says why a structural science can never reach the inside, and it keeps the inside. Nor does it claim proof from physics: the demonstrated results establish that the outside face is constructible, covariant, and exact, not that the ontology is true. What is offered is a hypothesis with a stated datum, a clean claim, a governing discipline, a bounded role for science, and a research program — held to the honesty of saying, at each step, which part is given, which is posited, and which is still open.

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